

UNION VOLUNTEER OFFICER (1837-61)

ELMER EPHRAIM ELLSWORTH

Born in Malta, New York, Ellsworth hoped to attend West Point but failed to obtain an appointment. He moved to Chicago in 1859, where he became a prominent militia officer, leading a unit attired in the flamboyant style of French Zouaves. In 1860, he entered the law office of Abraham Lincoln and campaigned for the future president in the election that year.

When war broke out, Ellsworth raised a regiment recruited from the firefighters of New York, the "Fire Zouaves." He led them into Alexandria, Virginia, in May 1861, where he was killed by an innkeeper for pulling down a Confederate flag flying from his hotel. In the North, Ellsworth's youth and his connection with Lincoln magnified the importance of his death; he came to be seen as one of the first heroes of the war.

